

PERSONAL STATEMENT

Do you feel like you've faced significant challenges in your life ... or not so much?

(And do you want to write about them?)

- If yes (to both), you'll most likely want to use Narrative Structure.
- If no (to either), you'll probably want to try Montage Structure.

The above links dive into greater detail if you're curious, but essentially, Narrative Structure is the classic story structure, focusing roughly equally on

a) Challenges You Faced

b) What You Did About Them

c) What You Learned. Paragraphs and events are connected causally. (Not casually, btw, but causally—as in, through cause and effect.)

Montage Structure focuses on a series of experiences and insights that are connected thematically (so, for example, 5 pairs of pants that connect to 5 different sides of who you are).

So how does structure play into what makes a great personal statement topic?

I believe a montage essay (i.e., an essay NOT about challenges) is more likely to stand out if the topic or theme of the essay is:

- Elastic (i.e., something you can connect to a variety of examples, moments, or values)
- Uncommon (i.e., something other students probably aren't writing about)

I believe that a narrative essay is more likely to stand out if it contains:

- Difficult or compelling challenges
- Insight

“Elastic” will vary from person to person. You might be able to connect mountain climbing to family, history, literature, science, social justice, environmentalism, growth, insight ... and someone else might not connect it to much of anything. Maybe trees?

“Uncommon”—every year, thousands of students write about mission trips, sports, or music. It's not that you can't write about these things, but it's a lot harder to stand out.

“Difficult or compelling challenges” can be put on a spectrum with things like getting a bad grade or not making a sports team on the weaker end, and things like escaping war or living

homeless for three years on the stronger side. While you can possibly write a strong essay about a weaker challenge, it's really hard to do.

“Insight” is the answer to the question “so what?” A great insight is likely to surprise the reader a bit, while a so-so insight likely won't. (Insight is something you'll develop in an essay through the writing process, rather than something you'll generally know ahead of time for a topic, but it's useful to understand that some topics are probably easier to pull insights from than others.)

To clarify, you can still write a great montage with a very common topic, or a narrative that offers so-so insights. But the degree of difficulty goes up. Probably way up.

Here, in **MY** opinion, are a few qualities you'll find in an outstanding personal statement:

1. **You can identify the applicant's core values.** In a great personal statement, we should be able to get a sense of what fulfills, motivates, or excites the author. These can be things like humor, beauty, community, and autonomy, just to name a few. So when you read back through your essay, you should be able to detect at least 4-5 different values throughout.

When you look for these values, also consider whether or not they're varied or similar. For instance, values like hard work, determination, and perseverance ... are basically the same thing. On the other hand, more varied values like resourcefulness, healthy boundaries, and diversity can showcase different qualities and offer a more nuanced sense of who you are.

2. **It's vulnerable.** We love when, after reading an essay, we feel closer to the writer. The best essays we've seen are the ones where a person has let their guard down some. Don't be afraid to be honest about things that scare, challenge, or bother you. The personal statement is a great space for you to open up about those aspects of yourself. As I say, *IT'S A JOURNEY OF INTROSPECTION!*

As you're writing, ask yourself: Does the essay sound like it's mostly analytical, or like it's coming from a deeper, more vulnerable place? Another way of asking this: Does it sound like the author wrote it using mostly their head (intellect), or their heart and gut? Remember, this is the “heart” of your application. It's a place for emotional vulnerability. After reading it, the admission officer should (we hope) feel like they have a better sense of who you are.

3. **It shows insight and growth.** Your personal statement should ideally have at least 3-5 “so what” moments, points at which you draw insights or reflections from your experiences that speak to your values or sense of purpose. Sometimes, “so what” moments are subtle. Other times, they're more explicit. Either way, the more illuminating, the better. They shouldn't come out of nowhere, but they also shouldn't be predictable.

You want your reader to see your mind in action and take that journey of self-reflection with you.

4. **It demonstrates craft (it's articulate and reads well).** While content is important, craft is what'll bring the best stories to life. That's why it's important to think of writing as a process—it's very rare to see an outstanding personal statement that hasn't go through at least 5 drafts. Everything you write should be carefully considered. You don't want your ideas to come off as sloppy or half-baked. Your reader should see the care you put into brainstorming and writing in every sentence. Ask yourself these questions as you write:

- Do the ideas in the essay connect in a way that's logical, but not too obvious (aka boring)?
- Can you tell that the author spent a lot of time revising the essay over the course of several drafts?
- Is it interesting and succinct throughout? If not, where do you lose interest? Where could words be cut? Which part isn't revealing as much as it could be?

Narrative outline (developed from the Feelings and Needs Exercise)

Challenges:

- Domestic abuse (physical and verbal)
- Controlling father/lack of freedom
- Harassment
- Sexism/bias

Effects:

- Prevented from pursuing opportunities
- Cut off from world/family
- Lack of sense of freedom/independence
- Faced discrimination

What I Did About It:

- Pursued my dreams
- Traveled to Egypt, London, and Paris alone
- Challenged stereotypes
- Explored new places and cultures
- Developed self-confidence, independence, and courage
- Grew as a leader
- Planned events

What I learned:

- Inspired to help others a lot more
- Learned about oppression, and how to challenge oppressive norms
- Became closer with mother, somewhat healed relationship with father
- Need to feel free
- And here's the essay that became: Easter

Montage outline:

Thread: Home

❖ **Bojangles**

- Values: family, tradition, literature
- Ex: "Tailgate Special," discussions w/family, reading Nancy Drew
- Perception, connection to family

❖ **Chinese sword dance**

- Values: culture/heritage, meticulousness, dedication, creativity
- Ex: notebook, formations/choreography

- Nuances of culture, power of connection

❖ **Lab 304**

- Values: science/chemistry, curiosity
- Synthesizing plat nanoparticles
- Joy of discovery, redefining expectations

Once you've got a solid outline, start drafting. A few really useful things for your first draft:

Don't worry about word count (within reason).

Don't worry about making your first draft perfect—it won't be. Just write.

Don't worry about a fancy opening or ending.

If your first draft of a 650-word essay is 800 or 900 words, cool. You'll have to cut eventually. But that's the easy part (you generally just hit "delete").